



14 | in 2010, it was said, “It will be rolled out.” But it wasn’t—because no state trusted them to implement, compensate, or execute correctly. There was simply no trust.

As the saying goes, when you point one finger forward, three point back at you. Tell me why you couldn’t implement it? Forget 70 years, even in 10 years (when the Congress-led UPA was in power.)

SINGH: When we analyse the decision, we feel that you have focused on *roti, kapda aur makan* (food, clothing, housing). These three words sum up the changes...

A: Absolutely. Our focus is the common man and the middle class; beyond basic necessities, also their aspirations. Many families ask: We have a small TV—why can’t we buy a larger one? We have a small house—why can’t we build an extra room or a first floor? We have kept middle class, poor, small and medium industries, and farmers in mind.

SHAKIL: Has this been done with an eye on the upcoming Bihar elections? Is it the BJP’s manifesto?

A: It is a manifesto for the 1.4 billion people who’ve been waiting for it. I remember the days when friends in the media would say over tea, “You’re getting beaten up because of GST.” I don’t know if it was sympathy or criticism. But such comments were made. Now I say to all citizens, the Prime Minister

“Petrol and diesel are not under consideration in this proposal placed before the GST Council. It is entirely with the states... the Council has to take that call”

guided me—he said from the Red Fort, and about eight months earlier, around the Budget— “Are you doing something on GST? Please do something.”

And once this package was ready, and even though the Council decides, I showed the PM a small glimpse. He said, “Alright, let’s see, get it passed in the GST Council.” Their expectation: reduce people’s tax burden. This is new—we prepared a high-rate (legacy) structure earlier based on pre-GST rates and tried to reduce it here and there. But this time, the full package of rate, slab and system came through.

SINGH: Did you get inspiration from other parties? Congress, Trinamool—everyone says you did this after eight years of pressure. They say these are their revised rates.